

REFERENCE CARD

The 13 IDEA Disability Categories

IDEA recognizes 13 disability categories for eligibility. Meeting a category is the starting point, not the end goal. What determines your child's program is the evaluation data, present levels, and your advocacy.

The 13 Categories

Category	Brief Definition	Notes for Parents
Autism	Developmental disability affecting social interaction and communication	Broad spectrum. Diagnosis and eligibility are separate steps.
Deaf-Blindness	Combined hearing and visual impairments cause severe communication or educational needs	Rarest category. Specialized programs often needed.
Deafness	Hearing impairment so severe that processing language through hearing is impaired	Different from Hearing Impairment in degree.
Developmental Delay	Delays in physical, cognitive, communication, social, or adaptive development	Only available for ages 3 to 9. Not all states use it through age 9.
Emotional Disturbance	A condition with emotional or behavioral characteristics that adversely affect education	Often underidentified. Behavior must be more than a response to circumstances.
Hearing Impairment	Impairment in hearing (permanent or fluctuating) not covered under Deafness	Includes conditions like auditory processing disorder in some cases.
Intellectual Disability	Significantly below-average intellectual functioning with adaptive behavior deficits	Formerly 'mental retardation.' Terminology updated in 2010.
Multiple Disabilities	Two or more disabilities whose combination creates severe educational needs	Cannot be served by a program for only one disability.
Orthopedic Impairment	Severe physical impairment that adversely affects educational performance	Includes cerebral palsy, amputations, and other physical conditions.
Other Health Impairment	Limited strength, vitality, or alertness due to chronic or acute health problems affecting education	Most common category for ADHD. Also covers epilepsy, sickle cell, diabetes, and more.

Specific Learning Disability	Disorder in basic psychological processes involved in understanding or using language	Largest category nationally. Includes dyslexia, dyscalculia, dysgraphia.
Speech/Language Impairment	Communication disorders such as stuttering, impaired articulation, or voice impairment	Second largest category. Often resolved or reduced by school age.
Traumatic Brain Injury	Acquired brain injury from an external force affecting educational performance	Does not include congenital or degenerative conditions.
Visual Impairment (including Blindness)	Visual impairment (including blindness) that adversely affects educational performance	Even with correction, if it affects learning the student may be eligible.

Key Principle

The category gets your child in the room. What you do at the table determines what they receive.

What the Category Does and Does Not Do

What the category DOES	What the category DOES NOT do
Establishes eligibility for special education services.	Determine the specific services your child receives.
Opens the door to an IEP.	Guarantee any particular level of support.
Satisfies one of two eligibility criteria under IDEA.	Define what your child is capable of. That comes from strong goals and data.
Creates a legal basis for evaluation and re-evaluation.	Limit the services or goals that can be included in the IEP.

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